

GIRAFFES AND OKAPI

Diverse in the fossil record, the Giraffidae is represented now by just five species from sub-Saharan Africa. Although giraffes live in a different habitat to the okapi, they share some common features, including a long, dark tongue, ossicones (horns) covered in skin, and lobed canine teeth. Otherwise they resemble the bovids, with cloven hoofs, a four-chambered stomach, and the incisors (upper front teeth) replaced by a horny pad.

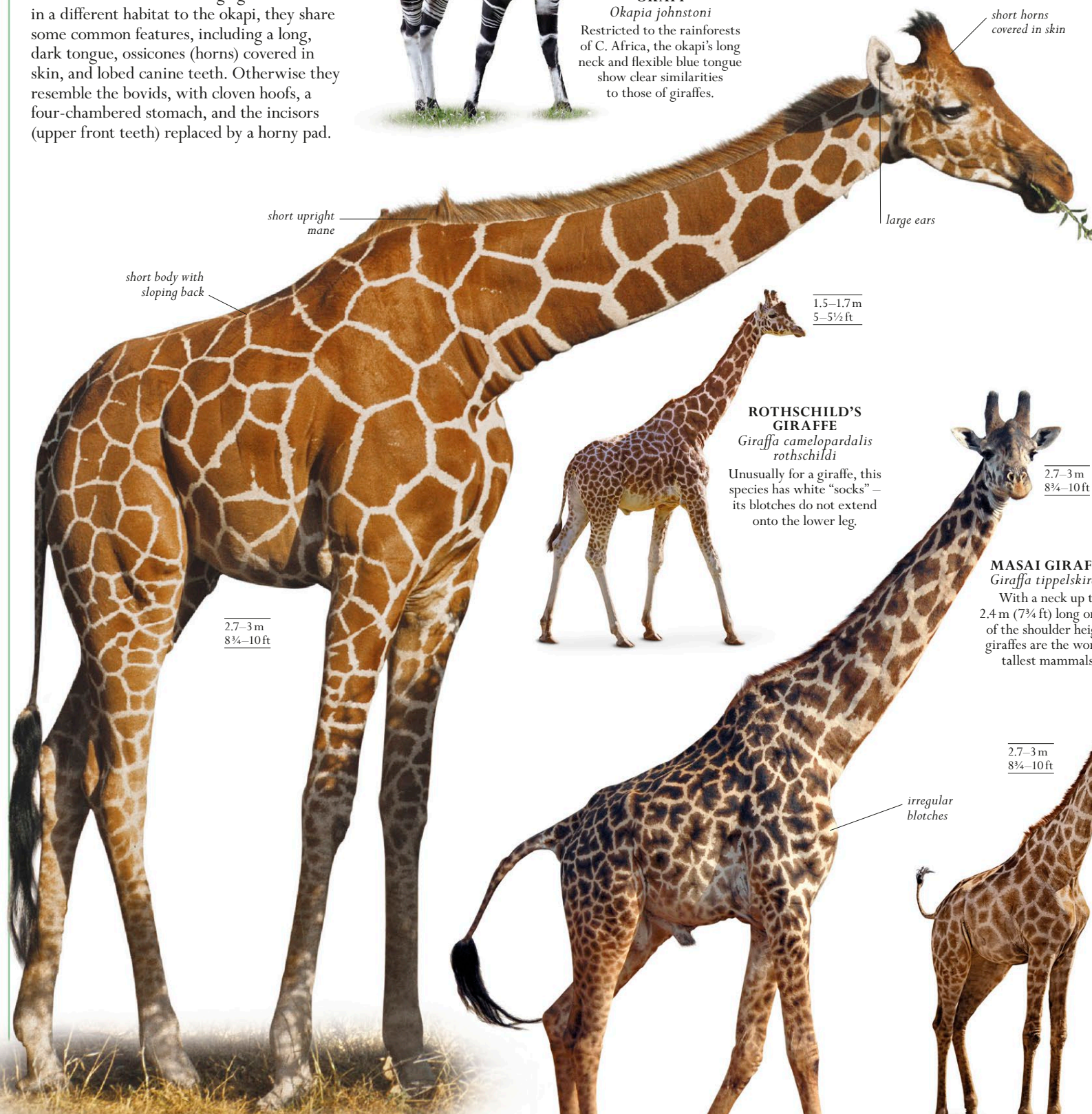


1.5–1.7 m
5–5½ ft

OKAPI

Okapia johnstoni

Restricted to the rainforests of C. Africa, the okapi's long neck and flexible blue tongue show clear similarities to those of giraffes.



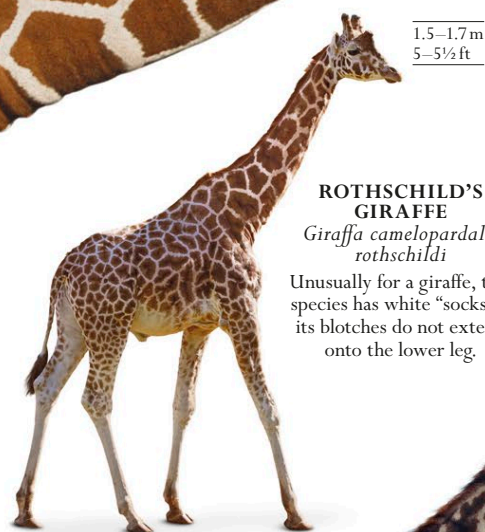
short upright mane

short body with sloping back

2.7–3 m
8¾–10 ft

large ears

short horns covered in skin



1.5–1.7 m
5–5½ ft

ROTHSCHILD'S GIRAFFE

Giraffa camelopardalis rothschildi

Unusually for a giraffe, this species has white "socks" — its blotches do not extend onto the lower leg.



2.7–3 m
8¾–10 ft

MASAI GIRAFFE

Giraffa tippelskirchi

With a neck up to 2.4 m (7¾ ft) long on top of the shoulder height, giraffes are the world's tallest mammals.

2.7–3 m
8¾–10 ft

irregular blotches

RETICULATED GIRAFFE

Giraffa reticulata

Ranging from northern Kenya to Ethiopia, this species of giraffe has large polygonal blotches, often with pale centres, on a pale background.

ANGOLAN GIRAFFE

Giraffa giraffa angolensis

One of two subspecies of southern giraffe, the Angolan giraffe is found in Namibia, Zambia, Botswana, and Zimbabwe.